

ILLUSTRATION BY **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

for land-owning farmers. This excludes an estimated 12.5 million tenant farmers and sharecroppers who work the land but do not own it. As a result, millions of vulnerable rural workers fall outside the net of support. The PRICE study emphasises that rural policy must shift from land-centric targeting to livelihood-centric design, ensuring that support reaches actual cultivators and workers, regardless of their formal land titles.

Another major challenge is

inequality across caste, gender, region, and income classes. General category annadata households earn nearly 50% more on average than their SC/ST counterparts. State-level disparities are even starker: average household incomes in Punjab exceed ₹20.6 lakh per year, while those in Chhattisgarh lag at around ₹3.2 lakh. Women, who make up one-third of the rural workforce, remain marginal in terms of land rights, credit access, and enterprise ownership.

The way forward must rest on three pillars: enabling diversification, deepening inclusion, and driving rural enterprise.

First, policymakers must recognise that diversification is not a deviation from agriculture—it is a strategic response to agrarian risk and stagnation. Farming incomes are increasingly vulnerable to climate shocks, price fluctuations, and input costs. Second, inclusion must be mainstreamed across every rural development initiative. Financial services, especially insurance and digital credit, must be reimagined for rural realities. Third, the future of rural growth lies in enterprise. With the right ecosystem—skilling, credit, digital infrastructure, and market linkages—rural India can be the next big entrepreneurial frontier. Skilling programmes should move beyond agriculture and incorporate digital work, green jobs, logistics, care work, and creative sectors.

Rural India is no longer just a market for low-cost goods; it is a space for innovation, services, and co-creation. Climate resilience must also be at the heart of rural policy. Investments in climate-smart agriculture, water harvesting, renewable energy, and low-emission enterprises will not only protect incomes but also position rural India as a leader in sustainable development.

Ultimately, a Viksit Bharat must be built on the strength of a confident, connected, and economically empowered rural India. What's needed now is a coherent, forward-looking strategy that views rural India not as a residual category, but as a driver of national development. **BT**

Views are personal